

Word family: **country / countries / countryside**

Base word: country

Plural: countries

Related form: countryside

Part of speech: noun (名詞)

Your sentence:

> “Instead of focusing on one **country** or one event, it appears to tell the bigger story of how human beings developed...”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **country** means an **independent nation or political state with its own territory, government, and population**.

繁體中文：***國家；具有自己領土、政府與人口的政治實體**

中文翻譯：

> “Instead of focusing on one **country** or one event...”

「它不是只集中講某一個**國家**或某一個事件……」

Here:

country = 國家

1. **country = nation/state (國家) — 國家**

This is the meaning used in your passage.

Meaning: A political territory with its own government, population, and borders.

Practice 1 — Original

> “The book does not focus on just one **country**.”

「這本書並不只集中討論某一個**國家**。」

Practice 2

> “She has visited more than twenty **countries**.”

「她去過二十多個**國家**。」

Practice 3

> “The **country** introduced a new education policy.”

「該**國家**推出了一項新的教育政策。」

****country = 具有自己政府、人口及領土的國家政治實體****

Common:

- * foreign country
- * developed country
- * neighbouring country
- * home country

2. ****country = the people of a nation collectively (全國人民) — 全國人民 ; 國民****

****Country**** can refer not to the land or government, but to the people of the nation as a whole.

Practice 4

> “The whole **country** celebrated the victory.”

「****全國人民****都在慶祝這場勝利。」

Practice 5

> “The news shocked the **country**.”

「這則消息震驚了****全國****。」

****country = 一個國家的人民整體，而不只是領土本身****

This is a metonymic extension of Meaning 1, but common enough to note.

For strict counting, I would usually merge it with #1.

3. ****country = rural area / land outside cities (鄉間) — 鄉村 ; 郊野****

****Country**** can mean rural land rather than urban areas.

Practice 6

> “They moved to the ****country**** after retirement.”

「他們退休後搬到****鄉下****居住。」

Practice 7

> “We spent the weekend in the ****country****.”

「我們在****鄉間****度過了週末。」

****the country = 城市以外的鄉村、郊野地區****

This is a genuinely distinct core meaning.

Important:

> ****the country****

can mean either:

* the nation

* the countryside

Context decides.

4. ****country = land/terrain of a particular kind (地帶 / 地形) — 地區 ; 地帶****

In some contexts, especially descriptive or outdoor English, ****country**** can mean a particular type of land or terrain.

Practice 8

> “They travelled through rough mountain ****country****.”

「他們穿越崎嶇的山區****地帶****。」

Practice 9

> “This is good walking ****country****.”

「這是一片很適合徒步的**地區**。」

****country = 某種具有特定地貌、環境或用途的土地區域****

This is distinct from both “nation” and “countryside,” though more domain-specific.

5. ****country = one's homeland/native nation (祖國 / 本國) — 祖國 ; 本國****

In phrases like:

> my country

> serve your country

> return to your country

****country**** can carry the sense of one's homeland or national home.

Practice 10

> “He returned to his ****country**** after many years abroad.”

「他在海外多年後回到自己的****祖國 / 本國****。」

Practice 11

> “She wanted to serve her ****country****.”

「她希望為自己的****國家****服務。」

This is not a separate semantic core from Meaning 1, but it is a common relational use.

6. ****country = country music (音樂) — 鄉村音樂****

In informal usage, especially in entertainment contexts, ****country**** can be short for ****country music****.

Practice 12

> “He mostly listens to ****country****.”

「他主要聽****鄉村音樂****。」

Practice 13

> “She is a well-known **country** singer.”

「她是一位很有名的**鄉村音樂**歌手。」

Here:

country = country music / 鄉村音樂

This is a lexicalized cultural use rather than an extension of “nation.”

Related form: **countryside**

Countryside means rural land outside towns and cities.

Practice 14

> “They went for a drive in the **countryside**.”

「他們到**鄉間**駕車遊覽。」

Practice 15

> “The **countryside** is especially beautiful in spring.”

「春天的**鄉郊**特別美。」

countryside = 城市和城鎮以外的鄉村地區

This overlaps strongly with:

> **the country** = 鄉下

but **countryside** is more explicitly geographic.

Important distinction: **country** vs **nation**

country

usually refers to the political/geographical entity.

nation

often emphasizes:

- * people
- * shared identity
- * culture
- * historical community

They often overlap, but are not always identical.

A **nation** can exist culturally or historically even without being a fully sovereign country.

Important distinction: **country vs state**

country

is the everyday general word.

state

can mean a sovereign political entity in formal/legal contexts.

> member states

> sovereign state

But **state** also has many other meanings, so they are not interchangeable everywhere.

Important distinction: **country vs countryside**

country

can mean either:

- * nation
- * rural area

countryside

specifically means:

- * rural land outside cities

So:

> “I love my country.”

= 我愛我的國家。

> “I love the countryside.”

= 我喜歡鄉村 / 郊野。

Important distinction: **country vs rural**

country

as a noun can mean the rural area.

rural

is an adjective.

> live in the country

> rural life

Not:

> “live in rural” ❌

Important distinction: **country vs land**

land

can mean:

* ground/earth

* territory

* countryside

* a country in literary use

country

more directly refers to:

- * a nation
- * rural area

So **land** is broader and more figurative in many contexts.

Countability note

For the nation meaning, **country** is countable:

- > a country
- > two countries

For the rural-area meaning, it often appears in the fixed phrase:

- > the country

not usually:

- > a country

when meaning “the countryside.”

For the terrain meaning, it can be uncountable-like:

- > rough country
- > open country

This distinction is useful.

Useful expression: **the country** — 鄉下 / 全國

This phrase is highly context-dependent.

Nation:

- > “The whole **country** was watching.”

「**全國**都在觀看。」

Rural area:

- > “They moved to **the country**.”

「他們搬到**鄉下**。」

Same form, different sense.

Family-extension note

The practical modern family is relatively small:

- * **country**
- * **countries**
- * **countryside**

Useful lexicalized constructions include:

- * home country
- * foreign country
- * the country
- * country music
- * country singer
- * open country
- * rough country

The key curation issue is to separate **nation** from **rural land**, while not over-splitting ordinary relational uses like “my country” or metonymic uses like “the whole country celebrated.”

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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country — nation/state	具有自己政府、人口與領土的國家政治實體
country — people of a nation	一個國家的人民整體；通常可併入 nation 義
the country — rural area	城市以外的鄉村、郊野地區
country — terrain/land	某種具有特定地貌或特性的土地區域
country — homeland	自己的祖國 / 本國；屬於 nation 義
country — music	鄉村音樂；詞彙化文化用法
countryside	鄉村、郊野、非都市地區

For your original sentence

> “Instead of focusing on one **country** or one event...”

The exact meaning is:

****country = 一個國家 / 政治實體****

So:

> ****one country****

= ****某一個國家****

The sentence contrasts a narrow focus on a single nation or event with a much broader view of human history.

For your database, I would count ****4 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****country****:

1. ****nation/state****
2. ****rural area — the country****
3. ****a particular type of land/terrain****
4. ****country music****

I would merge ****the people of a country**** and ****one's homeland**** into #1, and keep ****countryside**** as a closely related lexical family extension rather than a separate meaning of the base word.